

TAB 1



Board of Education Report

File #: Rep-114-25/26, **Version:** 1
In Control: Division of Instruction

Agenda Date: 10/14/2025

High School Physical Education Exemption Division of Instruction

Brief Description:

(High School Physical Education Exemptions) Recommends approval to authorize District high schools to grant physical education exemptions, upon parent request, for students who are 16 years of age or older and have successfully completed two years of physical education in grades 9 and 10.

Action Proposed:

Approval to authorize Los Angeles Unified high schools to grant a one-time, permanent physical education exemption, upon parent request, to students who meet the criteria: at least 16 years of age and successful completion of two years (four semesters) of PE in grades 9 and 10.

Background:

California Education Code Sections 51222, 51241(c)(1), and 51242 require students in grades 7-12 to complete at least 400 minutes of physical education (PE) every 10 school days for four years. After successfully completing two years of physical education, parents of individual students in grade 10 or above may request a permanent exemption, subject to local school board approval of the process, if they are 16 years or older.

Previously, students could earn a two-year PE exemption after 9th grade by passing five of six FITNESSGRAM components. As of 2022-23, that exemption (Ed. Code § 51241(b)(1)) is no longer available because FITNESSGRAM requires a BMI/body composition measure that cannot be assessed; without it, the test can't be completed, so the exemption cannot be issued.

Education Code Section 51225.3 states that all pupils receiving a diploma of graduation from a California high school must have completed two years or four semesters in PE. Consistent with this provision, LAUSD includes this as part of its graduation requirements.

The California Department of Education's Federal Program Monitoring (FPM) reviews LEAs for compliance with statutory program and fiscal requirements. In May 2025, FPM found two high schools out of compliance because most 11th-12th graders were not enrolled in PE. To correct this, the District must either (1) enroll all students in PE for all four years, or (2) seek Board approval for a statutory, districtwide exemption allowing 11th-12th graders who have successfully completed two years (four semesters) of PE to opt out. Following the pandemic-era pause, reviews have resumed; LAUSD is reviewed annually. Schools must maintain bell schedules that meet Education Code instructional-minute and credentialing requirements. Adopting the exemption would free student schedules for additional college preparatory or dual-enrollment. Failure to act may result in CDE monetary sanctions for noncompliance.

Expected Outcomes:

Approving this action would expand students' access to college and career opportunities by providing scheduling flexibility to take advanced math and science, dual-enrollment courses, and a fourth year of world language coursework that is critical for competitive college admission and career readiness. This exemption would also allow students to enroll in additional CTE coursework to prepare for careers. This change does not prevent students from taking a third or fourth year of PE, such as competitive sports or conditioning; rather, it empowers students to make choices that align with their individual goals and interests.

Board Options and Consequences:

If the Board approves this action and authorizes the exemption, students aged 16 and older, after completing two years of PE, will have greater flexibility in selecting courses during their junior and senior years. Some may choose to continue taking PE during all four years of high school, while others may opt for A-G courses, such as dual enrollment, AP, IB, or other college preparatory electives, that align more closely with their academic and career goals. Approval would also require students who turn 16 mid-semester to remain enrolled in PE for the duration of that semester, meaning they would take either a semester-long course or complete one semester of a year-long course.

If the Board does not authorize the exemption, students will be required to take PE all four years of high school, which may reduce the number of A-G elective courses available to them by two year-long or four semester courses. However, completing PE throughout high school provides opportunities to support student health, develop physical abilities, and build skills such as confidence, leadership, and teamwork through a variety of activities.

Policy Implications:

The decision to authorize or not authorize an exemption will have no impact on the current PE graduation requirement. However, if the exemption is not approved, this may impact students' ability to meet benchmarks and remain on track in other subject areas, such as Financial Literacy and other new requirements. As a result, this challenge will require our Districtwide benchmarks to be revised to indicate that physical education is required in grades 11 and 12, thereby reducing the number of opportunities for students to take additional courses. This change would also adjust how on-track graduation requirements are calculated in MiSiS and by the Office of Data and Accountability, which would need to be communicated with school staff, parents, and the community.

Budget Impact:

While the overall number of teachers needed may not change, not authorizing the exemption would likely result in the continued displacement of elective or content-area teachers, depending on the courses schools currently offer, leading to fewer course options for students.

Student Impact:

If the exemption is not authorized, students' available A-G coursework could be reduced by up to two, four year-long courses. This reduction may limit opportunities for advanced coursework, credit recovery, dual enrollment, and completion of CTE pathways, while also decreasing access to electives such as Leadership and JROTC. These limitations could negatively affect college readiness and postsecondary prospects, particularly since selective universities evaluate applications based on the number of A-G courses completed, the number of advanced courses taken, and the strength of a student's 12th-grade academic schedule.

Equity Impact:

Component	Score	Score Rational
Recognition	4	Approval of the exemption would allow students to take additional A-G courses and/or recover previously failed courses during the school day, thereby increasing their competitiveness for college admissions, supporting progress toward high school graduation, and better preparing them for postsecondary success.
Resource Prioritization	4	Expanding PE course offerings will require more teachers with PE authorizations, which in turn will reduce the number of teachers available in other content areas. As a result, schools will need to prioritize their course needs to determine which courses or subject areas will need to be reduced.
Results	4	Increasing course opportunities for students aged sixteen and older provides greater flexibility to prepare for postsecondary pathways, while still allowing all students to continue enrolling in PE courses based on their individual interests.
Total	12	

Issues and Analysis:

The Division of Instruction will collaborate with MiSiS to build an enhancement that enables schools to identify students with an approved waiver.

An analysis of estimated teacher needs for the Classes of 2026 and 2027 shows that approximately 760 additional PE sections and 152 PE teachers may be required if all students aged 16 and older are required to take PE (exact number of teachers will vary depending on bell schedules and number of students per school).

Each additional PE section could displace a section in another content area. For the Class of 2027, approximately 20,315 of the 28,398 students are not currently enrolled in a PE course and may need to be dropped from one A-G course.

Attachments:

Attachment A - 11th Grade vs. 12th Grade student schedule impact.

Submitted:

09/18/2025

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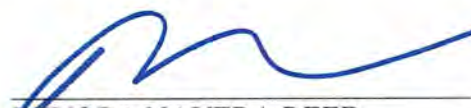
RESPECTFULLY SUBMITTED,


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ATTACHMENT A

Figure 1 and figure 2 show the current course schedules for an eleventh-grade student (Figure 1) and a twelfth-grade student (Figure 2). If an additional PE class were required, one of the courses listed on the right side of each figure would need to be dropped.

Figure 1: Current Eleventh Grade Student

Period	Course ID	Section	Course Number	Course Name	
1	-	2	654515	CTE INT PATIENT CARE A	← CTE
2	-	1	190119	CHORPROC SH A	← Art – F Requirement
3	-	3	370111	AP US HIST A	
4	-	5	310343	CC ALGEBRA 2A	
5	-	12	361001H	H PHYSIOLOGY A	← 3rd Year of Science
6	-	16	230111H	H AM LIT COMP	

If the exemption is not authorized, the current eleventh grade student above would not be able to take either a CTE concentrator, art elective, or third year of science.

Figure 2: Current Twelfth Grade Student

Period	Course ID	Section	Course Number	Course Name	
1	-	1	370907	AP MACRO ECONO	
2	-	4	361531H	H PHYSICS:THE UNIVERSE A	← 4th Year of Science
3	-	8	230208H	H ADV COMPOSITION 12	
4	F141	2	310701	AP CALCULUS A	← Advanced Math
5	F352	1	370403	INTRO PSYCH	← Elective chosen by student
6	-	1	256031	SPAN SP 1A	